



Isolated impact: Abhishek emerged as India's standout performer in the Pro League with four goals, but his tendency to hold onto the ball too long inside the circle often allowed defenders to recover and shut down scoring opportunities. AP

another from a shootout, India ended with 10 points. The relegation is embarrassing, but it also signals deeper concerns for the team than just a loss of prestige.

Close, but not close enough

Despite similar outcomes, the men are in a better position — both in terms of their shortcomings and the avenues available to address them. Barring a couple of games, they were never entirely outplayed. Six of their seven defeats came by a single goal, five of those in the final quarter. The team remained in the contest throughout but paid the price for a combination of erratic defending and poor decision-making in attack.

The tour began on the back foot: several squad members were unable to travel to Ireland for practice games due to visa issues. Injuries to Gurjant Singh and captain Harmanpreet Singh further compounded problems. Coach Craig Fulton's "defend-to-attack" philosophy —

which relies on a robust backline and elite fitness to transition quickly — was undermined by defensive lapses. India conceded 26 goals across eight games, with slack clearances, ill-timed tackles and poor positioning proving costly.

There was no dearth of experience — Amit Rohidas, Sumit, Jugraj Singh, Jarmanpreet Singh, Sanjay, and Harmanpreet — yet the group failed to play to its potential. Turnovers were frequent, and the basics seemed to have been forgotten, exposing a gap no strategic planning could paper over.

Goalkeeper Krishan Pathak had a tournament to forget, especially when dealing with aerial balls — a weakness the taller European teams exploited with ease. Suraj Karkera fared no better. Together, the duo made the absence of now-retired P.R. Sreejesh more glaring than ever.

Selection conundrum

Up front, Abhishek emerged as India's standout player, scoring four goals. Yet even he was guilty of holding onto the ball too long inside the circle, allowing defenders to regroup. His shot selection and angles saved him more than once, but simplicity could have been more effective. The rest of the attack was underwhelming. Mandeep Singh was

Broken transitions: Coach Craig Fulton's "defend-to-attack" philosophy — built on a solid backline and high fitness levels to enable quick transitions — was exposed in Europe as repeated defensive lapses cost India crucial moments and matches.

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used sparingly, Lalit Upadhyay (who has since retired) and Sukhjeet Singh were off-target, Dilpreet Singh looked unsure on the ball, and Shilanand Lakra lacked tenacity.

While Hockey India League and junior-level performers are waiting in the wings, Fulton has indicated that he does not intend to make wholesale changes until after the Junior World Cup later this year. Arajjeet Singh Hundal, Bobby Singh Dhami, Arshdeep Singh, Mohammed Raheel, and Selvam Karthi are all options — but the coach must soon decide whether to persist with the current group for the Asia Cup or accelerate the transition.

Penalty corner routines also need revisiting. In Harmanpreet's absence, India lacked a reliable drag-flicker. Rohidas was the next best; Jugraj continued his goalless streak and even missed a penalty stroke, Sanjay was ineffective, and Nilam Xess was